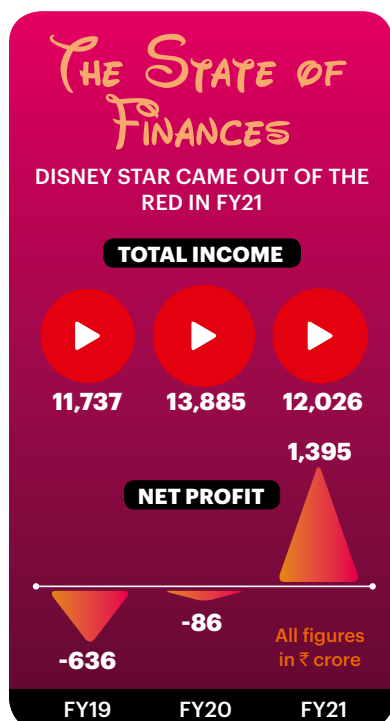
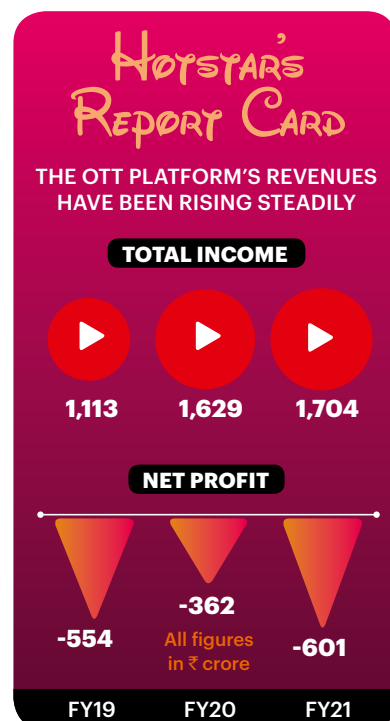




Note: These are standalone numbers and do not include Hotstar's financials
Source: RoC



Graphics by
TANMOY CHAKRABORTY



Hotstar is a brand owned by Novi Digital Entertainment, a subsidiary of Disney Star; Source: RoC

get a foothold in India or just abandon the idea. In contrast, Star under the Murdoch family had been more entrepreneurial with a greater appetite for risk; in the case of the IPL, it paid 2x more than incumbent Sony for half the period (Sony owned it for 10 years).

Madhavan, who had a long stint at Star and now works under a new owner, says both organisations have their individual styles. "We have picked up what works well and topped it up with our own experience of India. The transition has been smooth and this is a high-priority market for Disney," he says. With his background in finance (he was a banker till he joined the struggling Asianet in 1999 to turn it around before Star bought over most of it), his stint has seen Disney Star return to the black. Madhavan believes television and OTT offer immense potential. "Only 60 per cent of households have been



"Once 5G comes in, it can open up new features on multiple streams. We will have an audience who will start from 5G and that is a huge opportunity"

SUNIL RAYAN
Head of Disney+ Hotstar India

covered in the television story. For OTT, there is a total paid subscriber base of 50 million and another 300 million that are driven by advertising. On a compounded basis, it can grow by 30 per cent over the next five years," he outlines.

"Disney was never a strong contender in either broadcasting or OTT prior to the acquisition of Star. This deal directly catapulted them to the top position in both segments," points out Vivek Menon, Co-founder, NV Capital, a media and entertainment credit fund. With a growing subscriber base in OTT, there is no question of ignoring India. "Disney will continue to invest here to maintain that dominance. Globally, this is one of the biggest markets for Disney+ [the streaming service it launched in 2019]."

While Disney+ was launched from scratch in other markets, it had Hotstar, a ready-made platform, in India. According to Balu Nayar, for-